SAMPLE

Nineveh: The City of Yunus

Nineveh (نینوی) in the Quran

Aira Aurora

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Introduction

The Quran tells the story of a city that was not destroyed -- a city that was warned, that believed, and that was saved. In a Book filled with the stories of the destroyed nations -- the people of Nuh, 'Aad, Thamud, the people of Lut, the people of Madyan -- one city stands apart: the city that repented. The city is Nineveh, and the prophet sent to it was Yunus.

The Quran says:

"Why was there not a city that believed, and its faith benefited it, except the people of Yunus?..." (10:98)

Nineveh is the exception. Every other city that was warned was destroyed. The people of Nuh rejected and were drowned. The people of 'Aad rejected and were destroyed by the wind. The people of Thamud rejected and were destroyed by the shout. The people of Lut rejected and were destroyed by the stones. But the people of Nineveh -- the people of Yunus -- believed, and they were saved. The exception is the significance: Nineveh is the proof that the punishment is not inevitable. The exception is the lesson: the person who repents is the person who is saved -- and the city that repents is the city that is saved.

The story of Nineveh is also the story of the prophet who fled. Yunus left his city in anger before the command of Allah came, boarded a ship, was thrown into the sea, and was swallowed by a fish. In the darkness of the fish -- in the darkness of the sea, in the darkness of the night, in the darkness of the belly -- Yunus called out: "There is no deity except You; exalted are You. Indeed, I have been of the wrongdoers" (21:87). The prayer that was answered in the darkest place is the prayer that teaches: the person who repents in the darkness is the person who is brought to the light.

This book -- the ninth in the Places in the Qur'an series -- covers Nineveh: its name, its people, its prophet, his flight, his fish, his repentance, his return, the belief of the city, and its connections to the other sacred places. The book follows the same approach as the first eight books -- Makkah: The Holy City, Madinah: The City of the Prophet, Al-Quds: The Night Journey, Egypt: The Land of Pharaoh, Mount Judi: The Resting Place, Iram: The Lost City, Madyan: The Land of Shu'ayb, and Sodom: The Cities of Lut -- exploring the place as the Quran presents it.

The Places in the Qur'an series traces the sacred geography of the Quran. The eight previous books explored the centers of worship, community, tradition, trial, survival, transience, commerce, and immorality. This ninth book explores Nineveh -- the center of repentance. The nine places are the nine dimensions of the sacred geography: the House, the community, the tradition, the test, the survival, the transience, the commerce, the immorality, and the repentance. The person who understands the nine understands that the places where Allah acted are the places that teach -- and the city that repented is the city that teaches that the punishment is not inevitable and the mercy is always available.

Nineveh is the ninth pillar of the sacred geography -- the pillar that teaches that the city that believes is the city that is saved, and the person who repents in the darkness is the person who is brought to the light.

Chapter 1: The Name -- Nineveh in the Quran

The Quran refers to Nineveh through the people of Yunus:

"Why was there not a city that believed, and its faith benefited it, except the people of Yunus? When they believed, We removed from them the punishment of disgrace in worldly life and gave them enjoyment for a time" (10:98).

The people are the significance: the Quran identifies the city by the prophet who was sent to it -- "the people of Yunus." The people are the lesson: the city that is known by its prophet is the city whose fate is tied to its response to the prophet. The person who studies the name sees: the city that is not named by its location is the city that is named by its prophet -- because the defining event of the city is not its geography but its response to the message.

Nineveh is traditionally identified with the ancient Assyrian city on the eastern bank of the Tigris River, in what is now northern Iraq. The city was one of the greatest of the ancient world -- the capital of the Assyrian Empire, a city of walls and palaces and power. The location is the significance: the city that was the capital of the empire was the city that was given the prophet. The location is the lesson: the city that is the center of the worldly power is the city that is given the spiritual message -- and the message that is given to the powerful is the test for the powerful. The city that was great in the eyes of the world was the city that was tested by the God who is greater than the world.

The Quran does not mention the name "Nineveh" explicitly. The Quran refers to "the people of Yunus" (10:98) and to "Dhul-Nun" -- the one of the fish (21:87). The absence of the name is the significance: the city that is not named is the city that is known by its prophet. The absence of the name is the lesson: the importance of the city is not in its name but in its story. The city that is defined by its story is the city that is remembered by its story -- and the story that is remembered is the story of the repentance, the belief, and the salvation.

The Quran mentions the population of the city:

"And We sent him to a hundred thousand or more" (37:147).

The population is the significance: the city that had a hundred thousand or more was a great city -- a city of many people. The population is the lesson: the city that had many people was the city that was given the opportunity to save many people. The hundred thousand who were given the warning were the hundred thousand who were given the chance -- and the chance that was taken by the hundred thousand is the chance that is available to every person in every city.

Yunus is mentioned among the prophets in the Quran:

"Indeed, We have revealed to you as We revealed to Nuh and the prophets after him... and to Yunus, Harun, and Sulayman" (4:163).

The connection is the significance: Yunus who was sent to Nineveh was one of the prophets of the tradition -- the chain of the prophets that includes Nuh, Ibrahim, Musa, Isa, and Muhammad. The connection is the lesson: the prophet who was sent to the city of the empire was the prophet who was part of the same tradition as the prophets who were sent to the other cities. The message was the same -- the worship of Allah alone -- and the tradition was the same, from Nuh to Muhammad.

Nineveh stands apart from every other city in the Quran. The other cities that were warned were destroyed. Nineveh was warned and was saved. The standing apart is the significance: the city that is the exception is the city that proves the rule -- the rule that the punishment comes to those who reject and the mercy comes to those who believe. The standing apart is the lesson: the person who studies the cities of the Quran studies the pattern of the destruction -- and the one city that breaks the pattern is the one city that teaches that the pattern can be broken. The pattern that is broken by the repentance is the pattern that can be broken by every city -- and the city that repents is the city that is saved.

The fact that the Quran does not name Nineveh explicitly but refers to it through "the people of Yunus" is itself a lesson. The unnamed is the significance: the city that is not named is the city whose identity is in the response, not in the location. The unnamed is the lesson: the person who reads the Quran should understand that the identity of the city is not in its walls and its palaces but in its belief. The city that was the capital of the empire -- the city that had the name in the world -- is the city that is not named in the Quran, because the name that matters is not the name of the city but the name of the response. The response that is "they believed" is the name that endures, and the name that is the capital is the name that perishes.

The Quran connects the city and the prophet: "the people of Yunus" (10:98). The connection is the significance: the city is defined by the prophet, and the prophet is defined by the city. The connection is the lesson: the person and the place are linked. The prophet who is sent to a city is the prophet whose mission is tied to the city. The city that receives a prophet is the city whose fate is tied to the prophet. The two -- Yunus and Nineveh -- are inseparable in the Quran, and the inseparability is the lesson: the person who is sent by Allah is the person whose mission is the place, and the place that receives the person is the place whose destiny is the response.

The city that is named by the response is the city whose name is the faith -- and the faith that saved the city is the faith that is remembered in the Book.